SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 6, 2026

Pune Times Mirror Mumbai

www.punemirror.com

Sensex 76,515 | Nifty 23,897
Gold 1,54,800 | Silver 2,55,000
Dollar 94.49 | Euro 109.74
GBP 127.65

11 Pages Invitation PRICE Rs 5

Edition

MAX 31 | MIN 26 | HUMIDITY 76%

Inside Mirror


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Handi worth lakhs & worthless road



Breach Candy residents holding a meeting on Saturday

130-acre Coastal Gardens project

BREACH CANDY RESIDENTS UP IN ARMS

Locals question traffic, parking and pedestrian planning as plan takes shape

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For residents of Breach Candy, the biggest concern surrounding Mumbai's proposed Coastal Gardens is not whether the neighbourhood will get a new public space. It is how people will move through an area that is already congested throughout the day.

The Breach Candy Residents Forum held a community meeting on Saturday (September 5) to discuss the impact of the proposed gardens on the neighbourhood's liveability. At the centre of the resident's concerns are three issues: movement, parking and pedestrian safety.

Breach Candy has a unique mix of around 150 residential buildings, six schools and hospitals, apart from numerous shops, banks and other establishments. Residents say this combination creates bottlenecks through much of the day, rather than only during conventional morning and evening peak hours.

The concern is that the development of a major public destination on approximately 130 acres of reclaimed land could bring a substantial increase in visitor movement into streets that are already under pressure.

The revised Coastal Gardens masterplan reportedly proposes a 7.6-km pathway, 15 city-side entrances and more than 20 courts and fields, with multiple entry and exit points planned along the coastal stretch. Residents fear that even if some entrances are primarily pedestrian, visitors could still arrive by car, putting additional pressure on parking and local roads.

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A poster displayed at the venue of the meeting

CBI REGISTERS CASE AGAINST SUBHASH CHANDRA

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The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case against Essel Group Chairman Subhash Chandra and others for allegedly using inflated net worth certificates to secure loans from LIC Housing Finance Ltd (LICHFL). The loans subsequently went into default, allegedly causing the lender a loss of more than Rs 1,322 crore. The development comes days after the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) put on hold Chandra's Rs 6.25 crore repayment plan in a separate personal insolvency case.

The CBI case centres on net worth certificates submitted in 2018 to obtain two credit facilities totalling Rs 980 crore. One of the certificates placed Chandra's net worth at Rs 59,113 crore. However, during subsequent insolvency proceedings, he reportedly stated that his net worth in 2024 was just Rs 31.79 crore.

LICHFL alleged that the two loans were sanctioned and disbursed on the strength of the net worth certificates and personal guarantees furnished by Chandra.

The first facility, worth Rs 500 crore, was extended to Vasant Sagar Properties Pvt Ltd, with Pan India Infra Projects Pvt Ltd as co-borrower. The loan, sanctioned for takeover, top-up and business expansion, was backed by a continuing guarantee executed by Chandra on 28 March 2018.

According to the complaint, a certificate issued by DIM & Co on the same day placed Chandra's net worth at Rs 59,113 crore.

The second facility, worth Rs 480 crore, was extended to Digital Subscriber Management and Consultancy Services Pvt Ltd, with Spirit Infra Power and Multi Ventures Pvt Ltd as co-borrower.

AGENCIES



DEATHS OF SEWER WORKERS

HC slams state govt

'We reached the Moon, but manual scavenging still exists in Maharashtra'

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The court pointed out that workers continue to be forced into cleaning sewers and septic tanks, often without proper training, protective equipment or emergency safety arrangements

The Bombay High Court has delivered a scathing indictment of Maharashtra's failure to eradicate manual scavenging, observing that the country continues to be haunted by the caste system that pushes a particular section of society into work that no human being should be forced to perform.

A Division Bench of Justice Bharati Dangre and Justice Manjusha Deshpande made the hard-hitting observations while striking down a controversial clause in Maharashtra Government Resolutions that effectively shifted responsibility for compensation to private societies and contractors when sanitation workers died during hazardous cleaning.

The court's message was blunt: a worker's right to dignity cannot depend on who hired him.

Expressing anguish over the continued existence of manual scavenging, the Bench observed that while India proudly speaks of reaching the other side of the Moon, the reality of caste-based manual scavenging continues to stare society in the face.

The judges noted that despite 75 years of the Constitution, which guarantees equality before law, manual scavenging continues despite legislation and repeated judicial directions aimed at eliminating the practice.

The court pointed out that workers continue to be forced into cleaning sewers and septic tanks, often without proper training, protective equipment or emergency safety arrangements.

Policy that left families running from pillar to post

The case arose from a challenge to clauses contained in Maharashtra Government Resolutions issued in 2019 and 2025. The petitioners argued that the policy created an unfair situation for families of sanitation workers who died while undertaking hazardous cleaning for private societies or establishments. According to the petitioners, families were sometimes denied immediate assistance because authorities took the stand that the private society or contractor was responsible for compensation.

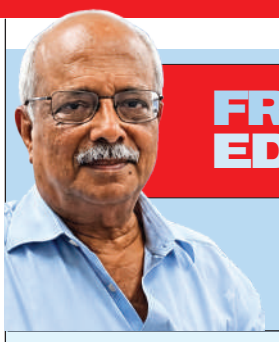
The Bench said the State and local authorities cannot wash their hands of responsibility simply because the deceased worker was employed for a private establishment.

The court directed the Maharashtra Government to identify, within six months, all persons who have died while undertaking "hazardous cleaning" as defined under the 2013 law.

Each deceased worker's dependants must be paid Rs. 30 lakh compensation, the court ordered.

Importantly, the State or local authority will make the payment first and can subsequently recover the amount from the concerned employer, private individual or establishment responsible for the work.

In other words, a grieving family should not have to fight a second battle for compensation while authorities argue over who should pay. The Bench held that Maharashtra's policy discriminated between sanitation workers merely on the basis of who employed them.



FROM THE EDITOR'S DESK

Pune Times Mirror, Mumbai
S Balakrishnan

Why kill soul of the civic body?

The proposed decision of BMC's standing committee to shift the main meeting hall, where the general body meets, to a new building in Azad Maidan is a grossly wasteful proposal. The beautifully chandeliered central hall at the BMC headquarters on Mahapalika Marg was where thousands of meetings of the general body were held and momentous decisions were taken. This hall is at the heart of the civic corporation's head office and as such holds tremendous historical and emotional gravitas. Its shocking that our corporators did not spare a thought for that and are going to vote on a proposal to hold the general body meetings in a building to be built where the BMC gymkhana presently stands on Azad Maidan at a cost of over Rs 50 crores. They will be killing the very soul of the richest civic body in the country by doing that. It is inconceivable that anyone could be even thinking of this grossly absurd proposal.

The reason given for the shifting of the hall to Azad Maidan is that it is unable to accommodate all corporators. The city is growing and along with it, the number of elected corporators will also go up. But surely it should be possible to accommodate all city fathers by relocating them in neighbouring halls with large digital screens.

Technology can be employed to conduct the proceedings of the general body without any hitch. But unfortunately this option has not even been considered by the administration. And pray what to what use the empty general body hall be used once the new building is built? Nobody in the civic headquarters has any clue about. Apart from that, why cannot Azad Maidan be left alone? There are already several structures there apart from the large Metro construction site and a reservoir. There is hardly any place for children to play. Kolkata and other metropolises boast of large maidans which are virtually free of structures.

One can have a clear view of these maidans from the road. But in Mumbai, citizens have to be told that there is a maidan called Azad Maidan in the heart of the city. On top of it, there are any number of illegal food stalls which pose a big danger to citizens' health. Already, the ratio of open areas to population is one of the lowest in the world. Mumbaikars should put their foot down and ensure that the general body meeting hall is not shifted to Azad Maidan. Instead of that, the area around the BMC head office needs to be improved majorly.

The pavement starting from Capitol cinema up to Hutatma Chowk on either side of DN Road is most unwalkable. So many tourists visit that heritage precinct and the uneven pavement is a positive embarrassment. It is high time the BMC gets its act together rather than undertake fancy projects which are not going to improve civic life even remotely.

Outsourced care under lens

Minister Abitkar puts services on notice

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Health Minister Prakash Abitkar holding a meeting

No more hiding shoddy service behind red tape. Health Minister Prakash Abitkar has put outsourced health services on notice, warning that everything from lab tests to dialysis will now be watched like a hawk under a brand new star rating system.

Chairing a high-level review at the Directorate of Health Services in Mumbai, Abitkar grilled officials on a long list of contracted out services such as mechanical laundry, HLL lab work, blood testing, X-rays, teleradiology, CT scans, MRIs, equipment maintenance, dialysis, diet supply, and sanitation support. His message was blunt, zero tolerance for malpractice, irregularities, or falling standards.

District surgeons and health officers have been handed marching orders to inspect services in their jurisdictions regularly and file quality reports. Quality healthcare for citizens, the minister stressed, isn't optional. It's the department's top priority.

The rating game

Under the new star rating system already rolled out across state run health institutions, hospitals will be judged on a tough checklist covering availability of specialist care, staff attendance, medicine stock, lab services, outpatient and inpatient care, number of deliveries and surgeries performed, cleanliness, facility usage, and crucially, patient feedback.

Abitkar also pushed for women's self-help groups to supply nutritious meals across public health institutions, with local MLAs roped into health committee meetings to track progress. A state level meeting of the Jan Arogya Samiti is slated for November, and the minister wants every district committee firing on all cylinders before then.

The initiative follows a major launch by Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, who unveiled three flagship projects: an Integrated Health Dashboard, an Integrated Health Facility Centre, and the hospital Star Rating System itself.

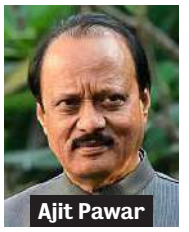
The government's line: don't just collect health data, put it to work for the people.

The review meeting saw Principal Secretary Dr. Nipun Vinayak, Secretary E. Ravindran, Health Services Commissioner Sanjay Katkar, Urban Health Mission Commissioner Dr. Sunil Bhokare, and Joint Director (Hospitals) Dr. Sunita Golhait in attendance, with district surgeons, health officers, and medical superintendents from across the state joining via video conference.

Probe sought into Ajit's death

SS (UBT) leader Arvind Sawant raises query

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Ajit Pawar



Arvind Sawant

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Arvind Sawant has questioned the decision to hand over the investigation of Disha Salian case to CBI while raising questions over why the death of former deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar has not been subjected to a similar probe.

Speaking at a press conference, Sawant said the demand for a CBI investigation in the Salian case stemmed from the perception among people that there was a possible conspiracy behind her death. He questioned why a similar standard of investigation was not being applied in the case concerning Ajit Pawar's death.

Sawant specifically referred to MLA Rohit Pawar's attempt to approach the police regarding the Ajit Pawar case. He claimed that Rohit Pawar had gone to the Marine Lines police station, where the senior police inspector was preparing to register an FIR. According to Sawant, a DCP subsequently arrived at the police station and instructed the senior inspector not to register the FIR.

THE BEAUTY CONVERSATION

Making Sense of Beauty

Conversation No. 001

WHY HAS SKINCARE BECOME SO CONFUSING?

We have more skincare products, more ingredients and more information than ever before. Yet now it takes two hours of scrolling, 10 saved reels, and a WhatsApp forward from siblings to figure out what to buy. With real progress in skin science and an explosion of content, skincare has somehow stopped feeling simple. So where exactly did we lose the plot? What changed?



Tanay Sharma,
Co-founder & COO, CITTA



Monisha Sharma
Cosmetic Technologist & Co-founder, CITTA | B.Tech Cosmetics



Akanksha Sharma
Co-founder & CEO, CITTA

Tanay: Okay, genuinely, when did buying skincare become rocket science? I remember a time when the biggest decision was choosing between two or three brands. Today, a single moisturizer shelf asks us to choose between hydration, barrier repair, and brightening. Then there are claims about peptides, ceramides, niacinamide, and whatnot. Why does buying a moisturizer feel like taking an exam?

Akanksha: That's because people aren't just choosing between products anymore. They're choosing between information. Every product tells a convincing story. Every influencer recommends something different. Every reel introduces a new ingredient you've apparently been missing all your life. By the time someone reaches the shelf, they're already carrying ten different opinions in their head.

Monisha: And then they look at the labels.
Hydrating.
Barrier Repair.
Clinically Proven.
Ceramides.
Peptides.
Prebiotics.
These are all useful terms.
But if you don't understand what they mean for your skin, more information doesn't necessarily make the choice easier.

> "One of the biggest mistakes people make is trying to recreate someone else's skincare journey instead of understanding their own skin. It's like copying your best friend's prescription glasses because you need specs too."
>
> **Monisha Sharma**
> Cosmetic Technologist & Co-founder, CITTA | B.Tech Cosmetics

Tanay: So, has skincare actually become more complicated? Or have we just made it feel that way?

Monisha: I'd say it's the second. Skincare today is more precise than it has ever been. We understand skin better and that allows us to create products for specific concerns. That's progress. The confusion starts when the science behind isn't explained clearly or isn't understood properly.

Akanksha: I'd add one more thing. Consumers today don't just want a product. They want to feel confident that they're buying the right one. Nobody wants to spend money on a serum or moisturizer and then wonder if they made the right choice. That's why everyone is searching for "the best." They're trying not to make the wrong choice.

Tanay: That's interesting. Because maybe the question itself is the problem. Instead of asking, "What's the best moisturizer?" consumers should ask, "What's the right moisturizer for me?"

Monisha: Exactly. There isn't one universally best moisturizer. A 22-year-old student in Mumbai with oily skin doesn't have the same needs as a 35-year-old woman in Pune with dry, damaged skin. If they both buy the same product because it went viral, one of them may be disappointed. Not because the product is bad. It just may not be the right fit for their skin.

> "Because maybe the question itself is the problem. Instead of asking, "What's the best moisturizer?" consumers should ask, "What's the right moisturizer for me?"
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> **Tanay Sharma,**
> Co-founder & COO, CITTA

Tanay: You know what strikes me? We have access to more information than ever before. Yet, many people feel less confident standing in front of a skincare shelf. How did more information lead to more confusion?

Akanksha: Because information and clarity aren't the same thing. Imagine asking ten friends to recommend a restaurant. Every recommendation might be genuine. But if all ten are different, you're still left wondering where to eat. Skincare is similar. Recommendations are useful. They're just not always personal.

Monisha: That's such an important distinction. Someone else's skin can make you curious about a product. It shouldn't automatically decide your routine. One of the biggest mistakes people make is trying to recreate someone else's skincare journey instead of understanding their own skin. It's like copying your best friend's prescription glasses because you need specs too.

Tanay: If skincare is so personal, why do people keep asking for one universal answer?

Akanksha: People are busy. They don't want to spend hours understanding ingredients. They want someone they trust to say, "Buy this. It'll work."

> "Nobody wants to spend money on a serum or moisturizer and then wonder if they made the right choice. That's why everyone is searching for "the best."
>
> **Akanksha Sharma,** Co-founder & CEO, CITTA

Monisha: But science rarely says, "This works for everyone." It usually depends on the concern, the conditions and how the product is being used.

Tanay: Which probably explains why one person calls a product life-changing... while another says it did nothing.

Monisha: Exactly. Both could be right. Different skin. Different climate. Different routines. Different results.

Tanay: I have another question. Has social media made skincare better or more confusing?

Akanksha: Both. People are learning about sunscreen, skin barriers, ingredients and much more in ways they never did before. That's a positive change. But on social media, every week there's a new ingredient, a new trend, or a new must-have. Naturally, consumers start wondering whether they're falling behind or stop listening altogether.

Tanay: I think we've also become impatient. Nobody really wants to wait three months to figure out whether a product is right for them.

Monisha: You're right, but skin changes gradually. Some concerns can improve in days. Some take weeks or months to show a visible difference. At the end, it's about consistency and severity.

Akanksha: Which is probably why people are researching so much. If brands don't communicate honestly, disappointment is inevitable.

Tanay: That raises an important question. What is a brand's responsibility here?

Akanksha: For me, it's transparency and education. If a person reads about a product, they should feel more informed rather than intimidated.

Monisha: And science shouldn't be used just to sound fancy. It should help them make better decisions.

Let's Pause Here

Before buying your next skincare product, ask yourself:
What am I trying to solve?
What is my skin telling me?
Am I buying this because I understand it, or because I've heard about it?
These questions can tell you more than the latest trend.

Beyond the Label

"The Best Moisturizer." It's one of the most searched phrases in skincare. In reality, there is none. You can find a moisturizer that's best suited to your skin, your concern, your environment and your routine. The search for "the best" can sometimes create more confusion than clarity.

Beyond the Label

"Clinically Proven" is a phrase we see everywhere. It generally means that a product or ingredient has been evaluated under defined test conditions. It doesn't automatically mean everyone will see identical results. Clinical evidence needs to be understood in context—alongside your skin, your concerns and what you're expecting from the product.



One Last Thought

The beauty industry has achieved something remarkable over the past two decades. We understand skin better than ever before. We have access to better ingredients, better formulations and better research. That should make skincare easier. Perhaps the next evolution in beauty isn't another breakthrough ingredient. It's helping people understand the choices already in front of them. Because better skincare doesn't always begin with a better product. Sometimes, it begins with a better question. "The biggest problem today isn't that skincare has become more complicated but choosing skincare has!"



METRO 5 GETS DEC DEADLINE

MMRDA says Thane–Dhamankar Naka phase on track, Bhiwandi extension clears key hurdle

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Commuters across Thane and Bhiwandi may be a step closer to travelling by Metro Line 5 as the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) has indicated that the first phase of the Thane–Bhiwandi–Kalyan Metro corridor is progressing with the aim of commencing metro services by December 2026. The update came after MMRDA responded to a letter from Bhiwandi MLA Rais Shaikh seeking information on the progress of the project and the tender process for its second phase. Shaikh subsequently shared the communication on social media, describing it as good news for Bhiwandi and Thane.



The first phase is a crucial section of the larger Thane-Bhiwandi-Kalyan corridor, which is expected to improve connectivity between major residential and commercial areas in the region

According to the MMRDA letter dated September 3, work on the first phase of Metro Line 5, between Thane and Dhamankar Naka, is progressing with the objective of starting metro services in December 2026. The authority also said preparations for the required Commissioner of Metro Rail Safety (CMRS) inspection are underway.

The first phase is a crucial section of the larger Thane-Bhiwandi-Kalyan corridor, which is expected to improve connectivity between major residential and commercial areas in the region. For Bhiwandi residents, however, the second phase has remained equally significant as it would extend the line towards Durgadi.

On this front, the MMRDA has indicated that important approvals are now in place. The authority stated that the Maharashtra government granted approval for the alignment of the second phase, from Bhiwandi to Durgadi, on April 22, 2026.

The alignment notification from the Union government's Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs was subsequently issued on August 30. With these approvals completed, the authority said steps are being taken to complete the tender-related process and commence actual civil works for the second phase at the earliest.

The development is significant because the Bhiwandi-Durgadi stretch will determine how quickly Metro 5 moves beyond its first operational section and deeper into Bhiwandi. The latest communication therefore provides a clearer timeline for both stages of the corridor, although the second phase does not yet have the same December 2026 service timeline mentioned for the first phase.

Shaikh's post has brought renewed attention to a project that has been closely watched by commuters in the Thane-Bhiwandi belt. The December target, if achieved, could provide a major alternative to road-based travel on one of the region's increasingly congested routes.

For now, the focus will remain on completing the first phase, securing the necessary safety clearances and moving the second phase from approvals and tendering towards ground-level construction.

BJP, MNS in war of words

Gajanan Kale lashes out at Ravindra Chavan

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The political standoff between the BJP and MNS in Maharashtra has now escalated into a war of words. Gajanan Kale, the MNS Navi Mumbai District President and spokesperson, questioned the criminal cases registered against BJP State President Ravindra Chavan, asking: if MNS workers are labelled as 'goons,' what term should be used for Chavan given the cases against him? Kale launched a scathing attack on social media, accusing Chavan of involvement in serious offenses such as rape and extortion.

Political rhetoric has intensified following a dispute between BJP Yuva Morcha and MNS workers regarding Amit Thackeray. Retorting to Chavan's remark calling Amit Thackeray a 'mere boy' (or 'novice'), Kale stated that it was these very 'boys' who had shown Chavan his true place. The BJP dismissed Kale's allegations as false, ridiculous, and politically motivated.



Ravindra Chavan (L) & Gajanan Kale

The party stated that full details regarding the cases against Chavan had been disclosed in his 2024 Assembly election affidavit. According to the party, these cases stemmed from political agitations; the matters have since been resolved in court, and Chavan has been acquitted. BJP Media Chief Govind Yetekar alleged that baseless statements are being made to tarnish Chavan's image and announced that legal action would be taken against Gajanan Kale. The controversy surrounding Amit Thackeray now appears to be heading towards legal proceedings.

Handi worth lakhs & worthless road

A ₹1,11,111 Dahi Handi prize banner stands tall, while residents say road is buried under potholes

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Residents of Hari Om Nagar in Thane East were confronted with a stark contrast on Thursday night, September 4, when they came across a banner announcing a Rs 1,11,111 prize for the person who breaks the Dahi Handi. The celebration may promise excitement and a sizeable cash prize, but the route residents had to take to reach the venue, particularly Chikhaladevi Road, presented a very different picture: potholes, damaged road surfaces and large stretches of stagnant water.

The photograph taken around 9.30 pm shows water accumulated across the road, making it difficult to distinguish the road surface from the waterlogged portions.

Residents say the condition has become so bad that they cannot properly see where the road ends and the potholes begin. For people walking, riding two-wheelers or travelling through the area, the waterlogging turns an already damaged road into a daily hazard. Residents are now questioning the priorities of the civic administration. Their concern is not about the Dahi Handi celebration or the prize money itself. The question is why public attention and resources appear to be available for festivities while basic infrastructure, such as motorable roads and proper drainage, remains a problem.



The banner displayed in Thane (L) and the waterlogged, damaged road

The contrast is difficult to ignore. A banner prominently advertises Rs 1,11,111 for one day's celebration, while barely a short distance away, residents are forced to navigate potholes and stagnant water simply to reach their homes and neighbourhoods.

The situation also raises questions for local corporators and the civic administration. How long have these potholes existed? How many complaints have residents made? Has the road been inspected? What action has been taken to repair the damaged stretches and address the waterlogging?

For residents, this is not merely an inconvenience. A road hidden beneath stagnant water can make potholes difficult to judge and increase the risk of falls, skidding and vehicle damage, particularly at night.

The Dahi Handi may be about breaking a handi, but residents of Hari Om Nagar are asking the administration to break a more pressing problem first: The cycle of potholes, waterlogging and delayed road repairs.

Prostitution racket busted

Two victims, including 12-yr-old minor, rescued

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The Anti-Human Trafficking Cell of the Crime Branch has busted a prostitution racket operating at 'Kohinoor Palace Lodging and Boarding' in Shiravane village, Nerul. During the raid, the police rescued two victims—including a 12-year-old minor—and arrested two lodge managers and a waiter.

Senior Police Inspector Gajanan Kadam stated that on September 3, they received a tip-off that women and minor girls were being forced into prostitution at Kohinoor Lodge.

A police team sent a decoy customer to verify the information; once the deal was struck and the signal was received, the team raided the premises. The investigation revealed that a minor girl and another woman were being held there for prostitution. The police took action after the accused accepted Rs 4,000 from the decoy customer in exchange for providing a woman.

The arrested individuals include lodge managers Hridaykumar Mahesh Singh and Deepak Jivandas Ramrakhiyani, as well as waiter Kuleshwar Kumar Singh. A case has been registered at the Nerul Police Station under the POCSO Act and the PITA Act. Apart from the three arrested accused, a search is underway for two others who remain at large.



Police personnel with the accused

ROW OVER DEMOLITION OF FOYER AREAS

Residents drag Rustomjee to HC

Seek ₹1,000 crore damages; court halts further demolition and seeks response from the builder

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They bought luxury homes in one of Mumbai's swankiest addresses. Now, some residents are fighting to save parts of those very homes from the demolition hammer—and have put a staggering Rs 1,000 crore damages claim on the table.

The Rustomjee Crown dispute in Prabhadevi has exploded into a full-fledged legal battle after residents moved the Bombay High Court against the developer and the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) following demolition of foyer areas inside apartments.

In a significant interim relief, the Bombay High Court has restrained the BMC from taking further action against the affected flats, while directing the developer to respond to the residents' suit.

The matter is scheduled for further hearing on September 17. The suit has been filed by 246 plaintiffs representing around 140 flat owners, who have accused the developer of misrepresentation, breach of contract and fraud. They have sought Rs 1,000 crore in damages, besides challenging the civic body's demolition notices and seeking protection against further demolition. At the centre of the controversy are foyer areas adjoining several apartments in the luxury complex.

The residents claim these spaces were represented as being for their exclusive use and were shown in marketing material, apartment plans and costing documents. They have alleged that the areas were effectively sold to them as part of their homes. According to the residents, around Rs 350 crore was paid collectively towards the foyer areas.

Their question before the court is simple but explosive: If the developer designed, marketed and sold apartments with these configurations, why should individual homebuyers now bear the consequences of alleged unauthorised construction?

The civic action began on August 24, when BMC officials demolished foyer structures in some apartments after issuing notices over alleged



AI GENERATED IMAGE

unauthorised construction. The civic body had reportedly issued notices to the first batch of 186 flats, with eight foyers in five-bedroom apartments already demolished. The larger action was expected to continue.

The residents, however, contend that the situation is not one of individual homeowners suddenly carrying out illegal alterations.

They claim the foyer configuration existed across a large number of apartments and that the spaces were reflected in documents provided during the purchase process.

The plaintiffs have also claimed that Towers A and B were inspected by the BMC before occupation certificates were issued in 2025, without objections to the foyer configuration at that stage. According to their case, the dispute surfaced later during the process concerning Tower C, when questions allegedly arose over excess FSI consumption.

They have questioned how hundreds of buyers could independently commit the same alleged violation when the disputed spaces were incorporated into the apartment layouts and, according to their claims, represented during the sale process.

They have therefore sought directions to regularise the foyer spaces, cancellation of the BMC orders and protection from further demolition.

They have also asked the court to preserve the developer's unsold inventory so that any eventual damages or court directions can be secured.

The developer, Rustomjee Group, has rejected the allegations. In its response, the company said the project was constructed in accordance with sanctioned plans and approvals issued by the competent authorities and applicable laws. It said it was examining the suit and obtaining legal advice.

The developer has maintained that there was no violation or non-compliance on its part and described the proceedings, at first impression, as misconceived.

The High Court's interim intervention gives residents temporary protection from further civic action while the dispute over the legality of the foyer spaces, the developer's role and the residents' claims is examined.

No HSRP, no problem!

Vehicle with 'corporator' sticker has non-standard number plate

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A car bearing registration number MH05EX0202 was recently spotted on the Kalyan-Dombivli Highway carrying a 'corporator' sticker, drawing attention to the vehicle's number plate, window tint and registration details.

The vehicle appeared to be fitted with a non-standard number plate instead of the prescribed High Security Registration Plate (HSRP), while its windows were visibly dark-tinted.

The vehicle is registered in the name of Neeta Jayanta Patil. The registration details available for the vehicle also mention an address at Sai Krupa Nivas, Sai Baba Mandir, near Tilak Vidya Mandir, Azde Gaon, Dombivli East, Kalyan.

The address has raised questions among residents familiar with the area. Sai Baba Mandir in Azde Gaon is situated



in the MIDC area, near K.V. Pendharkar College, while Tilak Vidya Mandir is closer to Dombivli railway station.

The two locations are separated by several kilometres. Whether the address has been correctly recorded in the vehicle's registration documents, however, would need to be confirmed by the concerned Regional Transport Office.

The vehicle's number plate is another point that warrants clarification. HSRPs are designed to follow a standardised format and include security features intended to make vehicle identification and enforcement easier.

Missing teen found

13-year-old who had disappeared located at temple in Mathura

Rutuja Joshi
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A three-day search for a 13-year-old girl who disappeared from her home in Borivli ended in an extraordinary moment in Mathura, when a Mumbai police officer spotted her at a temple immediately after praying for help in finding her.

The teenager, a devotee of Lord Krishna and Radha, had left her home in Gorai on August 22 without informing her family. Her disappearance prompted her mother and other family members to approach Borivli police, following which a missing-person investigation was launched.

The police said the girl had been strongly drawn to religious activities



AI GENERATED IMAGE

since childhood. She would make small idols herself, worship them and offer food to them. She also frequently watched television programmes based on Lord Krishna and other religious subjects.

According to investigators, her family had been concerned about her mental well-being and had brought her to Mumbai with the intention of seeking treatment. However, her interest in religious places remained strong.

A breakthrough came when investigators examined the girl's mother's mobile phone. Her recent Google searches reportedly included Mathura and several temples and places connected with Lord Krishna. This led police to suspect that the teenager may have travelled towards Mathura.

CCTV footage then helped investigators reconstruct part of her journey. She was reportedly seen travelling to Borivli railway station before boarding the Golden Temple Mail, which stops at Mathura Junction.

A team from Borivli police travelled to Mathura and began searching temples, ashrams and dharamshalas. After three days, the team was exhausted. An officer went to a temple, closed his eyes and prayed for guidance. When he opened his eyes, he noticed a girl. It was the missing teenager. The officer checked her photo and called out her name. The girl responded and appeared surprised that the officer knew who she was.

BREACH CANDY RESIDENTS UP IN ARMS

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Bhulabhai Desai Road remains a particular concern. Residents describe it as an extremely narrow road surrounded by residential buildings, shops and religious establishments. While we spoke to a resident from Breach Candy, they said, "Traffic is a regular problem and that even a 100 to 150-metre stretch can take around 10 to 15 minutes to negotiate while making a U-turn".

For residents, the issue becomes more serious when emergency movement is considered. With hospitals in the area, they say traffic planning must ensure that ambulances can move through the neighbourhood without being trapped in congestion.

Hence, residents are renewing their demand for a Napean Sea Road exit from the Coastal Road. They argue that a direct connection could reduce pressure on the internal roads and provide an alternative route for traffic. The BMC, however, has indicated that no decision has been taken on the proposed exit or flyover, citing the proposed landscaping and existing amenities along the Coastal Road.

Residents say they have also conducted a survey to understand traffic movement through Breach Candy and want that assessment to form part of the planning process.

The environmental aspect is equally important to them. They want the reclaimed land to provide trees, shade and spaces for people to sit and rest, rather than becoming an attraction dominated by hardscaping. They are also calling for climate-resilient planning, with surfaces and landscaping capable of helping absorb rainwater during heavy rainfall.

The residents' larger question is straightforward: If 130 acres are being planned as a public destination, has equal attention been given to how people will reach it, where they will park, how pedestrians will move and how emergency vehicles will get through?

For Breach Candy, the demand is not against public open spaces. It is for planning that protects the neighbourhood while creating them.

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PHOTOS: KALIDAS

ATHER KONARC S ALMOST THERE









Joshua Varghese
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@MadAutoTech

The Ather Konarc is an ambitious attempt to be the EV equivalent of India's favourite scooter, the Honda Activa. They tried it once with the Rizta but the response was lukewarm. Based on that experience, the Konarc should have been perfect. It is not. It is miles ahead of the competition in many ways but Ather has not cracked the formula for Indian families as effectively as TVS did with the iQube.

Comfort and convenience

For anyone shorter than six feet, a comfortable seating position is not tough to find and since the seat is well-cushioned, it is a nice place to be but the ride quality should be better. I expect a family scooter to waft over imperfections but the Konarc does not. Or rather, it did not when I rode solo. With a pillion onboard, the ride quality improved significantly.

Unlike some of its rivals, the Konarc can store a full-face helmet of good quality under its seat which, in my opinion, is the first step towards safety. By the way, a small light in the storage space would have been a useful addition.

'Airwalk' is another useful feature. The motor assists the rider when they are trying to push the scooter while parking which makes life easier. I also appreciate the addition of a backrest with the option of upgrading to an adjustable unit at an additional cost.

Performance

For reasons known only to Ather, the top speed of the Konarc has been restricted to 70 km/h, severely limiting its potential on open roads. Perhaps, it can be done with a software update. This scooter also has a poor selection of riding modes. S Eco and Eco are capped at 30 km/h and 50 km/h respectively. They offer lethargic acceleration and struggle to overtake a spirited cyclist. In comparison, Power mode is the most pragmatic because it accelerates unchecked until 70 km/h and then maintains that speed. Based on our experience in Bengaluru, we expect to receive between 80-100 km in Power mode.

Handling

The chassis and setup allow the scooter to carry speed confidently through a corner and keeps it unfazed even if the surface is a bit bumpy. The Konarc's front disc brake is among the best in the segment. Its power and precision allowed me to brake hard with confidence, so no complaints there.

Verdict

In many ways, the Konarc is a better attempt at a family scooter than the Rizta but to become a success, it must offer better suspension damping for a solo rider because comfort is key. It also needs a slightly higher top speed. In every other way, the Konarc is an excellent product. What I like best about Ather is that it develops its tech to improve its consumers' quality of life.

What do I have to say to Ather?

As always, I am blown away by your tech and the way you use it to make life easier. In my books, that places Ather higher than Honda in the EV space. That said, the Konarc was unconvincing as a family scooter. When it comes to choosing between plush ride quality and sharp handling, a family scooter must always choose the former.

Offering a 10-year warranty is extremely commendable but with all options included, the Konarc is simply too expensive for a scooter that is limited 70 km/h. A revision in pricing is advisable.

Price: ₹1.45 lakh ● MAT rating: 8/10

Pune Times Mirror
MAT
MAD AUTO TECH

WE SAMPLED ATHER'S LATEST ATTEMPT TO WIN OVER THE MASS MARKET. WE ALSO TESTED SAMSUNG'S LATEST SMARTWATCH FLAGSHIP.

Scan the QR code to visit the Instagram account of MadAutoTech

SAMSUNG GALAXY WATCH ULTRA 2 MARGINAL IMPROVEMENT

Ankit Dubey
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@MadAutoTech

Design and Build Quality

At first look, the Samsung Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 may not seem very different from the previous Ultra. It gets a 47mm titanium body, which feels premium and strong. Samsung has made the body slightly slimmer this time. It is now 10.7 mm thick, so it feels a little less bulky than the previous Ultra. However, it is still a large smartwatch, and people with smaller wrists may find it a bit big. For outdoor use, the watch is built to be tough. It comes with IP69K and 10 ATM water resistance.

Excellent Display

The display is a 1.52-inch Super AMOLED screen with a peak brightness of up to 5,000 nits. The biggest advantage of this is outdoors. Even under strong sunlight, the screen remains easy to read. The display is sharp and the colours look good. For activities like running, cycling or hiking, this bright screen is very useful.

Performance and Gemini AI

Samsung has also upgraded the processor this time. The Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 uses the Snapdragon Wear Elite chipset, and the watch feels smooth and fast in daily use. Opening apps, moving through menus and using different features is quick and responsive. Another interesting addition is Gemini AI. You can use it for things like setting a timer, checking your calendar, getting directions or sending messages. The Raise to Talk feature also makes it easier to speak to Gemini without having to type or press multiple buttons.

Health and fitness features

Health tracking is one of the biggest strengths of the Galaxy Watch Ultra 2. The watch can track heart rate, blood oxygen, skin temperature, sleep and several other health metrics. It also has a Vitals feature that looks at your health data and tries to understand your normal pattern. There are also features like Daily Cardio Load, Fitness Index and Energy Score.

The watch tracks different sleep stages and the Sleep Coaching feature gives suggestions to help improve your sleeping habits. For running and other outdoor activities, you also get dual-frequency GPS, which helps provide accurate location tracking.



Battery life

The Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 has an 800mAh battery, which is much larger than the 590mAh battery on the previous Ultra. With normal usage, the watch can last for more than two days, and depending on how you use it, you can get even more battery life. Fast charging is also available.

Should you buy it?

At Rs 64,999, the Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 is definitely not a cheap smartwatch. If you only want notifications, calls and basic fitness tracking, you don't really need to spend this much. But if you take fitness, running, cycling or outdoor activities seriously and want a strong and premium smartwatch, the Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 is a very good option.

Its biggest strengths are the rugged design, excellent outdoor display, improved battery life and wide range of health features. If you already have the first Galaxy Watch Ultra, upgrading is not necessary because the design and overall experience are quite similar but for a first-time buyer, the Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 is among Samsung's most complete smartwatches.

Pros

1. Excellent 5,000-nit display
2. Strong battery life
3. Great health and fitness tracking

Cons

1. Large and bulky design
2. Expensive at Rs 64,999
3. Some advanced features require a Samsung phone

Price: ₹64,999 ● Rating: 8.5/10

Bilateral trade is over $15 bn: Brazil Consul General
— Brazil Consul General Jose Mauro da Fonseca Costa Couto on Saturday said that bilateral trade between India and Brazil has grown tenfold over the past 20 years, from USD 1.5 billion in 2004 to over USD 15 billion at present.

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I may have been poisoned: Raut

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP says his illness originated in Arthur Road Jail where he had spent 101 days in custody

#MUMBAI
@ThePuneMirror

Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut has sparked discussion in political and medical circles with claims concerning his cancer diagnosis. Raut has alleged that his cancer may have originated during his time at Mumbai's Arthur Road Jail. He has also said he now suspects that he may have been subjected to some form of 'slow poisoning' through prison food or other means.

However, there is currently no medical or official evidence to establish that poisoning in prison caused Raut's cancer. Raut was arrested by the Enforcement Directorate on 1 August 2022 in connection with its investigation into the alleged financial irregularities in the Patra Chawl redevelopment case. He was subsequently sent to Arthur Road Jail in Mumbai. After spending around 101 days in custody, he was released on November 9, 2022.

Raut later wrote Narkatla Swarg ('Heaven in Hell'), a book based on his experiences in prison. The book describes prison conditions, the administration and his personal experiences during his incarceration.



Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi (left) and Sanjay Raut

Claim that cancer originated in prison

Raut has now made a claim concerning his cancer that was not widely discussed in connection with the book. During an interview at the Dinman Literature Festival in Kolhapur, he said, "The root of my cancer is in prison. I was diagnosed with cancer after I came out of prison." He also said he had noticed the beginnings of health problems while he was still in custody.

Suspicion of 'slow poisoning'

Raut was subsequently asked at a press conference whether he believed his cancer had been caused by food in prison and whether he suspected 'slow poisoning'. "I have started to feel that way now," he replied.

Raut said he believed the illness may have begun during his time in prison. However, he has not publicly identified any specific toxic substance or person whom he believes was responsible, nor has he produced any medical report or other evidence establishing poisoning. The allegation therefore remains a suspicion expressed by Raut and has not been independently verified.

Raut also referred to a meeting with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. He claimed that Gandhi had met him around 10 days earlier and had enquired about his health.

According to Raut, Gandhi told him, "Anything can happen to people like us in prison." Raut further claimed that Gandhi advised him to undergo a 'toxicology test' to determine whether there was any evidence of poisoning in his body.

There has been no independent official confirmation from Rahul Gandhi or his office regarding the remarks attributed to him. At present, therefore, the account of Gandhi's comments is based solely on Raut's statement.

Cancer diagnosis in 2025

Reports had previously stated that Raut was diagnosed with stomach cancer in 2025. He began treatment after the illness was detected shortly before Diwali. He has spoken on various occasions about undergoing treatments including chemotherapy and radiation. Although his cancer was diagnosed some time after his release from prison, the timing alone does not establish a direct connection between alleged poisoning in prison and the development of cancer.

Cancer can have multiple and complex causes. Establishing that a particular toxic substance caused cancer would require appropriate medical investigations, toxicological evidence and other supporting evidence. Raut has documented his 101 days in prison in Narkatla Swarg. In the book, he discusses overcrowding, sanitation, psychological stress and the lives of prisoners. He began writing the book while he was still in custody and completed a substantial portion of it during his incarceration.

His latest claims about his cancer have therefore also raised questions about his health records during his imprisonment and the medical reports and treatment he received after his release.

Need for medical evidence

The question of a 'toxicology test' has now become significant following Raut's claims. However, medical experts would first need to determine which toxic substances should be tested for, how long such substances can remain detectable in the body, and whether current tests could establish exposure that may have occurred several years ago.

Raut's suspicion is therefore serious, but at present it remains an allegation or claim rather than an established medical finding. The facts can be determined only if it is supported by credible medical and toxicological evidence.

In the meantime, his allegations could lead to renewed scrutiny of his health records, medical treatment and reports from the period of his imprisonment and the years that followed.

AGENCIES

Jarange's stir continues

Refuses medical treatment, IV fluids and water

#ANTARWALI SARATI
@ThePuneMirror

Manoj Jarange Patil's hunger strike demanding Maratha reservation entered its eighth day on Saturday, as thousands of Maratha protesters from across Maharashtra gathered at Antarwali Sarati, resulting in a massive crowd at the protest site. Concerns over Jarange Patil's health have increased after he once again refused medical treatment, IV fluids and water from Thursday night.

Jarange Patil began his 11th hunger strike on August 29, demanding recognition of Kunbi records for members of the Maratha community. On the seventh day of the protest, OBC leader and Minister Chhagan Bhujbal strongly criticised Jarange's agitation as well as the repeated visits by ministers to the protest site.

Bhujbal warned that he would take to the streets and fight if any attempt was made to undermine the constitutional rights of the OBC community. Jarange Patil subsequently responded to Bhujbal's remarks.

Bhujbal said ministers repeatedly visiting the protest site to persuade Jarange Patil to end his hunger strike was inappropriate. He said Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, chairman of the state government's sub-committee examining the Maratha reservation issue, had assured that a government resolution would be issued by September 10. However, Bhujbal warned that if the decision affected the rights of the OBC community, he would take to the streets and fight against it.



Manoj Jarange Patil

Responding to Bhujbal's criticism, Jarange Patil said the OBC community had now become more aware and vigilant. He called on caste verification committees not to do injustice to economically disadvantaged people. Jarange also warned that the Maratha community could distance itself from the Mahayuti alliance. He questioned whether the Mahayuti did not have the electoral support of the Maratha community.

Meanwhile, BJP MLC Prasad Lad said the decisions taken by the government would be sent to Jarange Patil in writing.

AGENCIES

Passengers denied concession

Confusion over NCMC card of MSRTC

#ALIBAUG
@ThePuneMirror

Confusion has intensified over the NCMC card introduced by the Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC) for passengers travelling at concessional fares. While ST officials claim that the deadline for obtaining the card has been extended until September 14, passengers have alleged that conductors are refusing to grant concessions, saying they have not received any instructions regarding the extension. The discrepancy between official orders and their implementation on buses is consequently leaving passengers to bear the brunt.

A large number of passengers gathered at the Alibaug bus station on Thursday to obtain NCMC cards. Long queues had formed outside the designated counter since morning. A significant number of women and senior citizens were among those waiting. Despite standing in queues for hours, several passengers had to return empty-handed as the counter closed before their turn arrived.

A senior citizen who had come to obtain the card expressed his frustration, saying, "I have stood in this queue three times so far, but I still have not received my card. Because the counter closes before my turn comes due to the time limit, I have to return and stand in the queue again the next day."



Passengers have therefore questioned whether they should spend days standing in queues merely to obtain a card intended to help them avail themselves of concessions.

The ST corporation provides various travel concessions to women and senior citizens. Divyang passengers and school students are also entitled to concessions under government rules. For several of these concessions, Aadhaar cards or other government-approved identity documents are accepted as proof. The ST also provides separate concession cards for certain categories of passengers.

Against this backdrop, passengers are questioning the need for the NCMC card in the first place. If the new card is intended to simplify the process of availing concessions, clear information should be provided to passengers and its implementation on buses should be made seamless. At present, however, confusion appears to exist at every stage — from obtaining the card to using it to claim the concession.

Passengers have also complained that some conductors have said they have not received any instructions regarding the extension of the deadline. As a result, some passengers are allegedly being denied concessional fares on the grounds that they do not possess an NCMC card and are being made to pay the full ticket fare. This has reportedly led to arguments between passengers and conductors.

Suhas Chaure, Divisional Controller, said, "NCMC cards have been given an extension until 14 September. Passengers should take note of this. Instructions regarding the extension are being communicated to conductors through the respective depots."

What is an NCMC card?

NCMC stands for National Common Mobility Card. It is a smart, cashless card that can be used to pay fares on public transport. The card can be used for ST bus tickets and functions much like a digital wallet. It is intended to reduce dependence on cash and make ticket transactions easier and more convenient.

AGENCIES



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MIGHT HIT PICKAXE: TRUMP

President defends military campaign against Iran

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror



President **Donald Trump (in pic)** on Friday (local time) said the United States could "hit" Iran's heavily fortified underground nuclear site known as Pickaxe Mountain "very soon", days after Washington targeted Iranian military targets.

Speaking to reporters at the Oval Office, Trump defended the months-long US military campaign against the Islamic Republic, saying its primary objective was to prevent Tehran from acquiring a nuclear weapon.

"We're in five months now. And you know what we did in five months? They're not going to have a nuclear weapon; that's what we did," Trump said.

"Iran will not have a nuclear weapon because if they did, you probably wouldn't be standing here very long," he added.

Trump then warned that Pickaxe Mountain could be targeted if the US detects activity there.


PIC FOR REPRESENTATIONAL PURPOSES ONLY

"We may hit Pickaxe very soon because if there was anything going on with Pickaxe," Trump said, adding that US intelligence was closely monitoring activity at the site.

"We know everybody that's moving at Pickaxe; we know everybody that's moving everywhere all over Iran. And if anything goes bad, we hit them; we hit them hard," Trump said.

Pickaxe Mountain is located near Iran's heavily damaged Natanz uranium-enrichment facility and is described as a heavily fortified underground complex containing two deeply buried tunnel systems.

The Wall Street Journal had earlier reported that Israeli intelligence believes Iran has relocated thousands of centrifuges to the deeply buried facility.

The underground construction of the site is believed to make it substantially more resistant to conventional aerial bombardment, making any potential US decision to strike it a significant escalation in the campaign against Iran's nuclear infrastructure.

Trump also argued that US military intervention had prevented a wider regional conflict, saying that without American action, Israel and the broader West Asia would have faced a potentially more serious threat.

"If we didn't go in there, you wouldn't have Israel right now, you wouldn't have the West Asia, and they probably would go at European cities and our cities next," Trump said.

"But we stopped them from having a nuclear weapon in five months," he added.

The remarks came days after the US Central Command said American forces had completed a wave of strikes against Iranian military targets.

According to CENTCOM, the operations targeted facilities associated with Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps last week, including air-defence installations, radar systems, maritime assets, mine-laying capabilities and communications sites.

CENTCOM saidthat the strikes followed what it described as recent "attempted attacks" by the IRGC against commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz and against US service members.

AGENCIES

Don backs VP's remark

'Vance is right, it is a military conflict, and not war'

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror

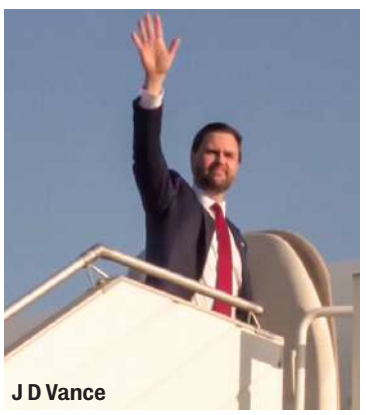
US President Donald Trump on Friday (local time) backed Vice President JD Vance's characterisation of the ongoing confrontation with Iran as not amounting to a war, describing the hostilities as an "intermittent" military conflict and calling it "small potatoes" for Washington.

Speaking to reporters at the Oval Office, Trump, when asked to clarify Vance's "not a war" remark after recent US strikes against Iran for the first time in several weeks, said, "A lot of people don't call it a war. I call it a military conflict because it's small potatoes for us; it's not a big thing."

The US President said that he understood Vance's position and argued that the current situation differed significantly from prolonged US wars in which American casualties were far higher.

"In Vietnam, you lost 100,000 people and in other conflicts, you lost tens of thousands of people," Trump said, referring to the scale of casualties in past conflicts. He added that the current confrontation was "intermittent" because the United States was carrying out strikes rather than engaging in continuous fighting.

"I could see somebody not calling it a war," Trump said.


J D Vance

Trump also claimed that the United States currently controls the Strait of Hormuz, a strategically vital waterway through which a significant volume of global oil supplies passes, which has seen major disruption due to the conflict in West Asia.

"There's no fighting. We're taking out a lot of oil, we control the Hormuz Strait, and we control it very strongly," Trump said, adding that US forces had conducted strikes on areas around the strait and destroyed radar installations.

According to Trump, US forces had also destroyed aircraft and other military assets that had been used to protect Iran's position around the Strait of Hormuz.

"We took out some aircraft; we took out some other things that protect for them—used to protect the Hormuz Strait when they had it under very tight control. But now we control it," he said. **AGENCIES**

Bessent hails Europe

'EU officially joined Operation Economic Outcast'

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Thursday (local time) said that the European Union has "officially joined" the US-led "Operation Economic Outcast" against Iran, welcoming what he described as the bloc's strong and early stance in maintaining economic pressure on Tehran as the West Asia conflict continues.

"The European Union has officially joined Operation Economic Outcast and we appreciate their strong and early stance," Bessent said in a statement on X.

"The United States stands firm with our allies in ensuring the murderous Iranian regime cannot exploit the global financial system to fund its nuclear ambitions, weapons programs, and terror proxies. The world is sending a clear message to the Iranian regime: We will not stop until every remaining financial lifeline has been severed," he added.

Bessent's remarks came after the EU said it was prepared to support additional economic pressure on Iran, including through the US-led operation, while stressing the need for continued diplomatic efforts and de-escalation.

"The European Union has consistently urged Iran to curb its nuclear programme, and its ballistic missile programme, refrain from destabilising activities in the region and in Europe, stop its military support for Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine and cease the violence and repression against its own people," the EU said in a statement shared by Bessent.


Palestinians inspect a mosque hit in an Israeli strike on August 25, carried out after the Israeli military warned residents to evacuate the area, in Deir al-Balah in the central Gaza Strip REUTERS/Mahmoud Issa/ANI Photo)

The bloc said it believes continued diplomatic efforts are necessary to reach a peace settlement, restore regional stability and ensure "full freedom of navigation and safe transit through the Strait of Hormuz".

The EU also said it had already adopted extensive sanctions aimed at preventing Iran from exploiting the global economy and financial system to sustain what it described as hostile actions and undermine international security.

"It remains ready to take further measures, where necessary, to safeguard its security and interests, including freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz," the EU said. **AGENCIES**

HEALTH TIP: The main sources of vitamin D are direct sunlight exposure, naturally rich foods like fatty fish, fortified products, and supplements. Your skin makes vitamin D when exposed to ultraviolet B (UVB) rays from the sun.



Spending about 10 to 30 minutes in the sun a few times a week is often enough, depending on your skin tone and location.

ASK THE SEXPERT



DR ROHAN JAHAGIRDAR
Psychiatrist & Sexpert

1 I'm a 24-year-old male. My girlfriend has had many boy-friends before me. How can I get the best at my sexual perfor-mance with her?
Dear Sir, it would be BEST if you focus on having a stable and fulfilling relationship with her. Take professional help if needed. Comparing yourself to others would be a sign of your poor self esteem and is not going to gain anything. All the BEST!

2 I'm a newly mar-ried girl. I feel very anxious and worried about how I look while having sex with my husband. Is it normal?
Mam, many people worry about how they look while being intimate. It can be due to many factors: performance anxiety, poor self image/ body image, adjustment and trust with the part-ner etc. As you are newly married your anxiety should settle down in a few days if not, please see a counselor.

3 I'm a 22-year-old female. I have still not been intimate with anyone. Is it a good or bad thing?
Mam, it is a completely personal and independ-ent choice. You should not feel pressured. It should be a right experience with the right person. You can definitely take your time.

4 I'm a 26-year-old fe-male. My friend told me men don't lie while having sex so can I ask my husband anything during the act?
Dear Mam, kindly commu-nicate with your husband directly! Asking him wrong questions during the act could complicate your sexual life. Trust me I'm not lying to you! (pun intended).

SEND YOUR QUERIES RELATED TO SEXUAL PROBLEMS TO
sexpert@punemirror.com

SMART AGEING: NEW SCIENCE OF LONGEVITY & REGENERATIVE AESTHETIC MEDICINE

ASK THE FACE EXPERT



Dr Prajakta Kulkarni,
Specialist in Advanced Aesthetic and Anti-Ageing Medicine, Facial Aesthetics Expert & Clinical Cosmetologist, Founder of The Face Studio, Prabhat Road

I am 48, and my skin has become loose and saggy. Is non-surgical face lift possible for me?
In recent years, Ultherapy or High-Intensity Focused Ultrasound (HIFU) has emerged as a revolutionary solution for deep tissue anti-ageing treatments. Combining cutting-edge technology with noticeable results, it has gained immense popularity among individuals seeking non-invasive and effective methods to combat the signs of ageing.
HIFU, also known as Ultherapy or High-Intensity Focused Ultrasound, is a non-surgical and non-invasive procedure that uses focused ultrasound energy to stimulate collagen production deep within the skin. By targeting specific layers of tissue, HIFU treatments can effectively lift, tighten, and rejuvenate the skin, resulting in a more youthful and radiant appearance almost instantly, with the best results appearing 2-3 weeks post session.
HIFU has many aesthetic benefits, including: wrinkle reduction, tightening sagging skin on the neck (sometimes called turkey neck), lifting the cheeks, eyebrows, and eyelids, enhancing jawline definition, tightening of the décolletage and firming & smoothing the skin.

THE FACE STUDIO
BY DR. PRAJAKTA KULKARNI
A Bespoke Aesthetic Experience

I wish to undergo an anti-ageing treatment but don't find the idea of injectable anti-ageing treatments appealing. Are there other ways to do anti-ageing treatments?
Yes. With the advancements in technology, we can now use minimally invasive to completely non-invasive methods to treat signs of ageing. Laser skin resurfacing is one such non-invasive procedure that uses laser technology to improve the texture and tone of the skin. It works by removing the outer layer of damaged skin, stimulating collagen production, and promoting the growth of healthier, younger-looking skin. This treatment can effectively reduce fine lines, wrinkles, tighten loose skin, and improve the appearance of scars and pigmentation issues.
You can even opt for a Platelet-Rich Plasma (PRP) therapy that utilizes the body's own healing properties to rejuvenate the skin. PRP therapy can help improve skin texture, reduce the appearance of wrinkles, and enhance overall skin tone. This treatment is safe, natural, and has minimal downtime, making it a sought-after option for those looking for a more holistic approach to anti-ageing.
Other non-invasive anti-ageing treatments include customised chemical peels, dermabrasions, radiofrequency, ultrasound energy devices etc. We would recommend you consult with an Aesthetic Physician for more treatments for intelligent ageing.

I am a 37-year-old male. When should I start anti-ageing treatments?
The blue light from our screens, sun exposure, unhealthy eating practices and ineffective lifestyle are impacting our skin and overall health negatively, thereby ageing us in the process. Therefore, it becomes essential to start an anti-aging regimen even before you've started showing signs of ageing. Ideally, one can and should start anti-ageing treatments from their late 20's to early 30's. However, it's never too late to start. If you are just starting out and have never taken a treatment, I would recommend incorporating anti-ageing formulations like retinoids, vit C, alpha hydroxy acids etc in your skincare.
Ageing is a natural process that everyone goes through. As we age, our bodies undergo various changes, including the appearance of fine lines, wrinkles, sagging, owing to loss volume and elasticity. However, with advancements in medicine and technology, there is now a wide range of anti-ageing treatments available to help you in smart/ intelligent ageing.
New age technology, now makes it possible to treat signs of ageing with non-invasive methods.

The views/suggestions/opinions/data in the article are the sole responsibility of the expert/organisation.
For more queries, write to **askthefaceexpert@punemirror.com**

NO POLITICS, PLEASE!

Study identifies brain areas that influence political intensity

A person's level of political engagement can be influenced by a variety of factors, including education and environment. A study led by Northwestern University and Shirley Ryan AbilityLab, has for the first time revealed which brain networks control political passion.

The study analysed Vietnam War veterans with and without brain injuries. By comparing people who had very localised brain lesions with those who didn't, the study team was able to identify the brain structures that can modify the intensity of political feelings.

Damage to the prefrontal cortex, a region responsible for cognitive control and reasoning, led to an increase in the intensity of political feelings. Conversely, damage to the amygdala, a brain structure involved in emotional processing, decreased political intensity in participants. These findings held true even after accounting for factors like age, education, party affiliation, personality traits and other neuropsychiatric symptoms.



"While most people have not sustained brain injuries akin to those experienced by the veterans in the study, our findings tell us what neural circuits are at play for the population at large," said senior author Jordan Grafman, professor of physical medicine and rehabilitation at Northwestern University Feinberg School of Medicine and director of brain injury research at Shirley Ryan AbilityLab.

"We didn't find brain networks tied to liberal or conservative ideology, but we identified circuits that influence the intensity of political engagement across the political spectrum," Grafman added. "This suggests that factors like emotion shape how pre-existing political beliefs are expressed, rather than determining ideology itself."

Recognising these brain mechanisms can help guide people in productive political engagement. For instance, one strategy would be to engage with others while reducing emotional attachment, or to take the position of an adversary in a discussion. Another approach would be to collaborate on a project both sides support.

The findings also have clinical implications. Currently, neuropsychiatric assessments rarely include questions about shifts in political behavior, but Grafman suggests they should. "Like other aspects of social behavior, assessments should consider asking whether a patient has experienced changes in their political attitudes since their brain injury," he said.



Grafman and his team studied Vietnam veterans with and without brain injuries as part of the Vietnam Head Injury Study, a long-term project on the neurobehavioral effects of combat-related brain injuries. Grafman has led this study since his time in the U.S. Air Force decades ago.

Between 2008 and 2012, neuroscientists conducted extensive behavioral questioning on these veterans, assessing various aspects of their political beliefs and intensity of feelings -- roughly 40 to 45 years after their injuries. Participants reported both their current political behavior and their recollections of pre-injury political behavior.

The study included 124 male U.S. military veterans with penetrating head trauma and 35 combat-exposed control participants who had not sustained brain injuries.

Prior to the questioning, scientists had already mapped the veterans' brain lesions using lesion network mapping, a neuroimaging technique that identifies the broader brain circuitry connected to a given lesion. They then analyzed whether specific brain networks were linked to political beliefs based on the behavioral data.

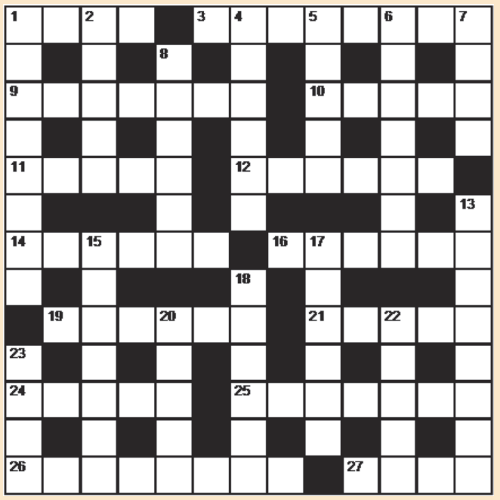
Grafman, who has also studied links between the biological and cognitive underpinnings of religious fundamentalism, says understanding the brain's role in shaping beliefs "allows us to better assess meaningful aspects of life for patients and healthy individuals." Additionally, he says, "we expect this research will point to ways we can assist patients in recovering from brain injuries." **ANI**

Chai-Time

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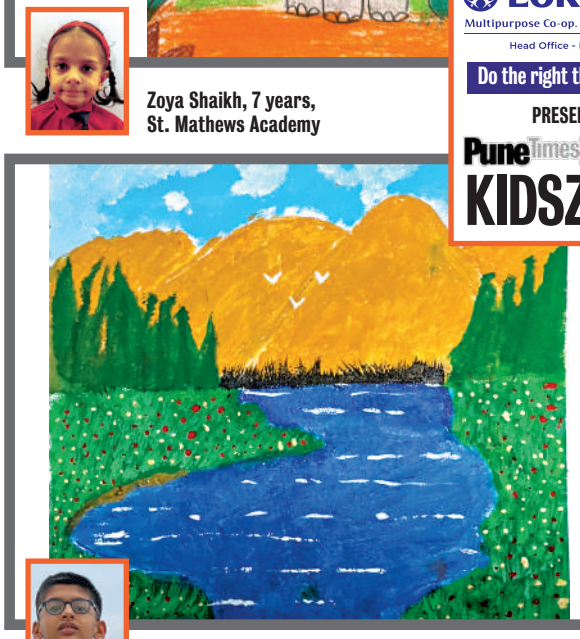
ACROSS
1 Look after (4)
3 Shoulder ornaments (8)
9 Droplet (7)
10 Meaning or inclination (5)
11 Creature (5)
12 Boredom (6)
14 First class (6)
16 A Spanish dance (6)
19 Stage whispers (6)
21 Go in (5)
24 Mexican friend (5)
25 Mishandled or vandalised, in a way (3-4)
26 Oscar winner starring Holly Hunter (3,5)
27 ___ for : seeks to obtain? (4)

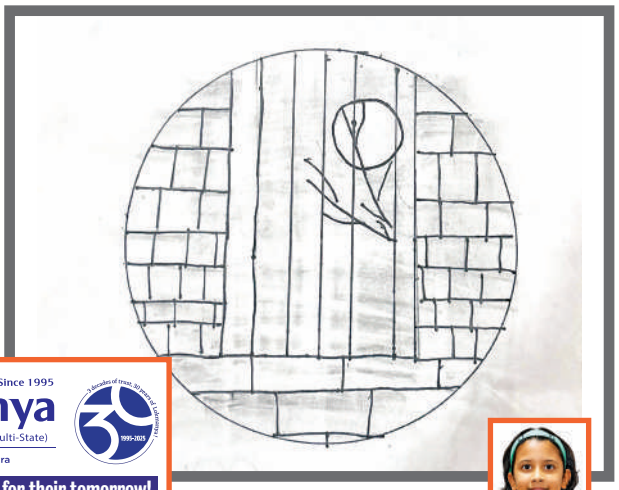
DOWN
1 Unit of computer storage (8)
2 Supermodel Campbell (5)
4 Bollywood's ___ Zinta (6)
5 Reversed (5)
6 Gourmet (7)
7 Location (4)
8 Keen for action, combat (4-2)
13 Rusts, deteriorates or erodes (8)
15 Leisure occupation (7)
17 Frankly; not secretly (6)
18 Distribute or delegate; hand over (6)
20 Loincloth (5)
22 Cricket matches (5)
23 Pune's __ Street (4)

FOR ANSWER SCAN ↓

Please send copies of your children's artworks along with a photo of the artist in A4 size.
Do mention their age and the name of the school they attend. You can also mail us unpublished poems by children.









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WHAT YOUR STARS SAY TODAY



Aries
March 21 - April 20

Your relationships will feel smoother with your circle. Good news arrives by mail. That fresh breeze of optimism in you also sparks a strong urge to get away—which can sometimes tip into excess, especially when it comes to your physical drive.



Taurus
April 21 - May 20

The weight of your worries is finally starting to lift. You did well to stick to your determination. Your inner strength is on the rise, keeping your energy steady and strong. Get moving with a bit of exercise!



Gemini
May 21 - June 21

You're having a slightly complicated, demanding day. The outside world has been pushing back hard for a while, and it's not easy to feel fully in control. This is the moment to reclaim your independence—gently, but firmly.



Cancer
June 22 - July 23

Fruitful conversations are on the horizon. Don't hesitate to seek legal advice. Don't let other people's needs take over—it'll cost you. You can't afford that.



Leo
July 24 – August 23

Today, your circle is demanding. Practically only you can keep your cool—and you do, staying grounded no matter what. Your energy rises and falls with your activities, and today, more than ever, it's all about how you move through your day.



Virgo
August 24 - September 23

The vibe is supercharged today. Passion is driving you like a tidal wave. You have everything to gain by putting your energy into the right first direction—rather than risking the kind of frustration that hits for real.



Libra
September 24 - October 22

Your love life is front and center. You're thinking about building a fortress around your most important connections—one nothing can shake. Take the time to savor the thrills that are right within reach.



Scorpio
October 23 - November 22

Follow the instinct of your heart—today, luck is on your side. Don't hold back from stepping into new possibilities, pouring more of yourself into them, and finding the escape you've been craving.



Sagittarius
November 23 - December 22

You're not fooled by the lies swirling around you. Stay discreet, and you'll see what's really going on beneath the surface. Ease your stress with floral essences—this will be especially beneficial for you. Think about it!



Capricorn
December 23 - January 20

Today, you'll have everything you need to tackle the problems that have been holding you back. Your inner strength will carry you through. New hopes are taking root in you—and for good reason!



Aquarius
January 21 - February 19

You'll find it easier to connect with interesting people. Something fresh is in the air. Here you go—ready to dive into serious home projects... The foundation is there, especially when it comes to building strength.

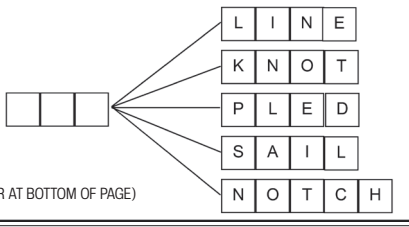


Pisces
February 20 - March 20

When the worry finally lifts, you'll feel yourself moving closer to a long-held dream. It may even become more real than you ever imagined. Right now, what you truly need is a vacation—some quiet time alone to take stock.

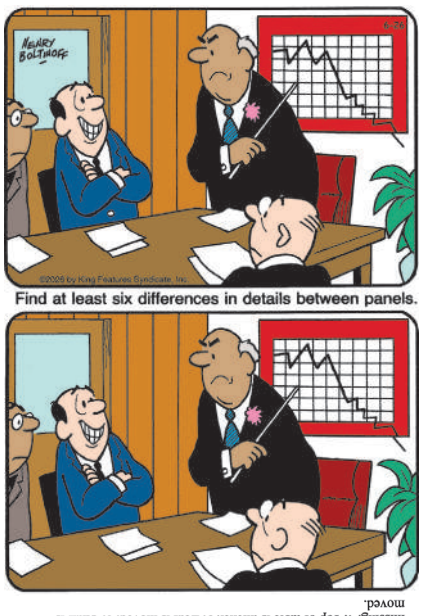
DOUBLE - BARRELLED

What word can be placed in front of the five words shown to form in each case another word ?



(ANSWER AT BOTTOM OF PAGE)

HOCUSFOCUS



Find at least six differences in details between panels.

Differences: 1. Papers are moved. 2. Ear is different. 3. Button is missing. 4. Top of table is thicker. 5. Leaf is moved. 6. Chair is moved.

ANSWER FOR DOUBLE-BARRELLED : Top

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